

Title PL Russia and Belarus Allege Polish-Ukrainian Terrorist Scheme

23/04/2025

Summary

- On April 6, the State Customs Committee of Belarus claimed it stopped 580 kg of explosives from being transported from Poland to Russia. Polish authorities dismissed the claim as disinformation.
- Belarusian and Russian state-linked sources alleged that the explosives plot was a joint operation by Polish and Ukrainian security services to stage attacks in Russia.
- Between April 6 – 9, the story appeared in over 300 Russian-language media reports, and the original Russian narratives were later spread in Polish news media and on Telegram.
- The campaign used impersonation, distortion, and state-aligned messaging to degrade adversaries, amplify propaganda, and exploit a breaking news event.
- Recommendations include countering the disinformation by exposing the false narrative, coordinating clear messaging across agencies, engaging watchdogs and monitoring amplification channels.

Incident

On April 6, the State Customs Committee of Belarus claimed that on April 2, they had intercepted the largest-ever shipment of explosives at the Belarus-Poland border—over 580 kg of pentaerythritol tetranitrate, a powerful explosive. According to the news media, the explosives were likely US-made, hidden in a car with Moldovan license plates, driven by a Belarusian citizen, Evgeny Manko, who had been hired by an Estonian national to deliver the vehicle to Russian city of Pyatigorsk. Following the incident, Belarus claimed that President Putin personally thanked President Lukashenko for the seizure. However, Poland's National Revenue Administration, and the Disinformation Analysis Center at NASK cast serious doubt on the story, warning it may be disinformation. Amid this, former Polish judge Tomasz Szmydt—who fled to Belarus in 2024 and now works with Belarusian state-controlled media—impersonated a Polish journalist Witold Jurasz. He called several Polish institutions, including the Border Guard in Terespol and NASK, fishing for sensitive information about the alleged smuggling. Belarusian media turned the calls into a propaganda segment.

Narrative

Meta-narrative: Poland is portrayed as a security threat to both Belarus and Russia;

Sub-narratives:

The explosives originated in Poland and were purchased by the Polish Armament Agency;

Polish and Ukrainian security services allegedly planned to carry out an explosion inside Russia;

Western security services allegedly planned to carry out a terrorist attack in Russia on May 9, the Victory Day there, to thwart peace talks with Ukraine;

Polish authorities only focus on migration flows, while their Belarusian counterparts “systematically combat real threats”.

Impact

Media coverage: Between April 6 and 15, around 400 articles about the alleged explosives incident were published online according to Meltwater. More than 250 originated from Russia, over 55 from Belarus, at least 15 in Moldova, and 79 in Polish, 40 of which appeared on the Portal combat network (examples below).

Languages and platforms: According to Osavul, between April 6 and 12, over 1,700 messages related to the incident were posted across platforms. More than 800 appeared on Telegram, over 150 on X, and nearly 100 on Facebook. These messages came from a wide range of locations: around 300 from Russia, over 180 from Belarus, more than 120 from Italy, over 70 from the U.S., nearly 60 from Germany, and over 40 each from Ukraine and Moldova. By April 12, the messages had generated more than 7.8 million views and over 300,000 reactions.

Penetration into Polish information sphere: A post by the pro-Kremlin Telegram channel *NOWости | Мировые события*, which claimed that the Polish Armament Agency had purchased the explosives and that they were manufactured in Poland, was translated into Polish and reposted by at least four other Telegram channels (here, here, here, here). Portal-Kombat network also amplified Russian propaganda narratives in Polish (here, here, here). At first, Polish news media treated claims from Belarusian state media as factual and largely repeated the

same narrative, but later Polish news media started adding a warning message that this incident might be disinformation.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective 1: T0066: Degrade Adversary – damage Poland’s reputation by alleging it was involved in plotting a terrorist attack.

Objective 2: T0002: Facilitate State Propaganda – rally citizens around pro-government narratives and portray an external threat as a danger to national security.

T0068: Respond to Breaking News Event or Active Crisis – generate a sensational news event and draw media attention to spread negative messaging about the opponent.

T0143.003: Impersonated Persona + T0097.102: Journalist Persona – using an actor linked to the Belarusian state to pose as a Polish journalist, aiming to damage Poland’s reputation and stir further controversy around the incident.

T0044: Seed Distortions – circulate multiple narratives early on about which countries might be responsible for the incident to sow confusion and mislead the public.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Continuing to monitor media ecosystem in Belarus, Russian and Poland;

Recommendations: Strengthen counter-disinformation messaging; Conduct attribution & amplify exposure; Coordinate messaging across government agencies; Engage civil society and media watchdogs;

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
N/A	Belarus, Russia	Upon request	Givi Gigitashvili, the DFRLab Larissa Doroshenko, Alliance for Securing Democracy	Telegram, YouTube, website	